DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Can Man Rise Higher and Fall Lower Than Any Creature?

Daat Tevunot §158

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §158 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 4 September 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Back after the summer

After the summer break the class began Section 8. The Rabbi decided not to review all the earlier sections yet. The plan was to work through Section 8 over the Yamim Noraim and Sukkot, review everything after Sukkot, and then finish Sections 9 and 10.

He placed the section in the book. The first part dealt with Yihud and its phases. The second dealt with body and soul and with evil. The third part deals with the ways Hashem acts upon the world. Section 7 covered the emanations that act on the world "from the outside", which bring good and bad. Section 8 covers the emanations within creatures themselves, what causes their changes and their different stages and times.

A different kind of emanation

The Sekhel says (§158) that so far we have discussed the emanations that cause events in the world, for good and for bad. Now we must understand the existence of the lower creatures, mainly man, the changes in their existence and the laws that govern them.

The Rabbi stressed the difference. What happens in the world, whether there is peace or war, an earthquake or calm, whether you have a good life or a hard one, belongs to Section 7. Section 8 is about what happens within you: the changes of level a person goes through in life.

The soul of souls

Every creature exists only because Hashem constantly sends it an emanation. "If God was for a moment to remove this emanation, all of existence in one moment would become nothing." The Rabbi repeated his analogy. Close your eyes and build a fantasy universe in your mind. The phone rings, and it is gone.

The Ramhal compares this to the soul sustaining the body. The Rabbi explained that nefesh here is best translated as "consciousness" or "life force". When it leaves, the body stops working and is buried. In the same way Hashem's emanation sustains every creature, and that is why the Hakhamim call it "the soul of souls". Our bodies need a life force, and that life force itself needs a further emanation in order to exist.

A participant asked whether all creatures have a soul. The Rabbi said the nefesh is the lowest of the five levels of the soul, simple animal life. Animals certainly have one and a stone does not. Science is starting to suggest that plants have some kind of feeling, "and if that's the case, then we'll have to say they have a nefesh as well".

Creatures have limits

The changes in creatures, up or down, depend on this emanation and the laws Hashem set. Each creature can rise only so far within its essence and fall only so far. Asked whether Moshe could have gone higher, the Rabbi said, "I don't know. Maybe, maybe not." But there is a limit.

Man: above everything or below a mosquito

The main creature is man, and within mankind, Israel. Hazal say that a time will come when the angels will ask Israel, "What has God done?", as if Israel are inside and the angels outside.

Man has a double nature. Hazal say: if he is worthy, we tell him that all of creation was made for him. If not, we tell him that the mosquito came before him. Man was created last. Either everything was made for him, or even the insects of the fifth day came first, "who do you think you are?" No creature is as open to bad as man, because only man has the capacity to sin. But when he is perfected, he rises higher than any other creature, and all of creation depends on him.

This is why Israel are compared both to the stars of heaven and to the dust of the earth.

A note on Jews and non-Jews

The Rabbi said this was not the place to go into the subject, which they had discussed at length in Derech Hashem. There are two schools of thought. The Ramhal, following the Arizal and the Ramban, holds that there is an intrinsic difference between Jew and non-Jew. The Rambam and the Ralbag hold that there is no intrinsic difference, and that the Jew has the misvot, which give him more ability to refine himself. Either way, non-Jews are fully part of this discussion of elevation and debasement.

Evil turned into good

The Ramhal ties this to the Yihud. The purpose of everything is the revelation of Hashem's oneness, and that comes about when evil itself testifies to it: when we see that the bad was really good. "I will thank You, for You have afflicted me." This can happen only through man. Evil has to exist within him so that, when he rectifies himself, the bad becomes good.

The Rabbi explained that the yeser hara actually takes part in your reward, because you can only choose good when there is bad to reject. Looking back, it turns out that "the bad itself is good". Footnote 11 in the English edition puts it this way: evil becomes the cause of man's greatest good and bears witness to God's oneness.

The moon

The Ramhal ends with an analogy. Man is like the moon, which is dark and only shines by reflecting light, and even then only partly. Man has nothing of his own except through his connection to Hashem. Footnote 13 sums up: this force within us has a dual nature, lofty in potential but lowered and exposed to evil, and once evil is overcome it will shine with great light. The Rabbi recalled the Midrash that the moon was diminished after it complained, and the prayer said each month that the light of the moon will be like the light of the sun. For now we only reflect the light, but in the end we will have a light of our own.

Summary

- Section 8 turns from what happens to the world to the forces within creatures that cause their changes.
- Every creature is sustained by a constant divine emanation, "the soul of souls", and without it would cease to exist.
- Every creature can rise or fall only within its limits.
- Man is the most exposed to evil and also capable of the highest elevation. All creation was made for him, or even the mosquito came first.
- Evil within man exists so that it can be turned into good, which reveals Hashem's oneness. For now man is like the moon, reflecting a light that will one day be his own.

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